

WHISPER PAGES

Product & Platform Specification Report

An Anonymous Writing & Storytelling Platform

Prepared for: ZeroOps Product Planning

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1. Executive Summary

Whisper Pages is a free, publicly accessible writing platform built around one core principle: the writing matters, not the writer's identity. Anyone can create an account under a self-chosen pen name and publish stories, essays, poetry, or short-form confessions without disclosing any personal information — no email, no phone number, no verified real name.

Unlike mainstream blogging and social writing platforms (Medium, Wattpad, Substack, Instagram), Whisper Pages deliberately avoids identity profiling. There is no algorithmic tracking of who a person is outside the platform, no cross-linking between accounts, and no monetized attention economy built on personal branding. The product exists to give people — particularly those with stories they would not feel safe telling under their real name — a space to write honestly.

This report documents the full feature set agreed upon during product planning, the reasoning behind each decision, the moderation and safety systems required to make anonymity sustainable rather than a liability, and a recommended technical architecture and rollout plan.

Key Differentiators

- No email, no recovery — pure username and password authentication
- No identity profiling, ever — profiles exist only at the pen-name level
- Self-certified age gating for both readers and content
- Automatic content review triggered by community reports
- Accounts that go inactive for 300 days are permanently destroyed and their pen name released

2. Vision & Design Philosophy

2.1 The Problem With Identity-First Platforms

Most writing and social platforms today are built around persistent, verifiable identity. Real names, linked emails, contact syncing, and algorithmic recommendation all combine to make a writer's real-world identity inseparable from their content. This discourages vulnerable, honest, or controversial writing — people self-censor because a post is permanently tied to their reputation.

2.2 The Whisper Pages Approach

Whisper Pages inverts this model. A pen name is the only identity that exists on the platform. There is no verified backend link between a pen name and a real person beyond what is strictly required for legal and safety compliance (see Section 16). This is not an anti-moderation stance — it is a deliberate design choice to separate reputation risk from honest expression, while still holding harmful content accountable.

2.3 Guiding Principles

- Anonymity by default, not as a premium feature.
- No recovery mechanisms that would require personally identifying information.
- Moderation is content-based and pattern-based, not identity-based.
- Every feature that could re-introduce identity profiling is scrutinized and scoped tightly.
- Growth should come from the quality of writing, not personal branding or follower counts.

3. Target Users & Core Use Cases

3.1 Who This Is For

- Writers who want to publish personal essays, fiction, or poetry without reputational risk.
- People processing difficult experiences (grief, relationships, mental health, family conflict) who want to write about them honestly.
- Students and young writers experimenting with voice and style without judgment from peers or institutions.
- Readers who want raw, unfiltered writing rather than algorithmically optimized, personal-brand-driven content.

3.2 Core Use Cases

1. A writer publishes a short story under a pen name and builds a following purely through their writing.
2. A reader browses trending or tagged stories without needing an account.
3. A user posts an anonymous shoutout or confession on the Wall without it being tied to their writing profile's reputation.
4. A writer receives comments and likes, moderates their own comment section, and blocks abusive pen names.
5. A user reports content that violates guidelines; the system auto-hides it pending review after enough reports.

4. Account System & Authentication

4.1 Signup Flow

Account creation requires exactly three inputs: a pen name (username), a password, and a self-certified age bracket. No email, phone number, or third-party OAuth login is collected at any point.

Username (Pen Name): Publicly visible identity. Must be unique across the platform. No real-name verification of any kind.

Password: The sole credential tied to the account. Checked against a blocklist of common/breached passwords (Section 5) at signup time.

Age Bracket: Self-declared by the user; used to gate what content they can see (Section 8).

4.2 No Recovery, By Design

There is intentionally no “forgot password” or “forgot username” flow. This is a deliberate trade-off: adding recovery would require collecting an email address or phone number, which would reintroduce exactly the kind of identity trail this platform is built to avoid.

Trade-off Acknowledged

- Users who forget their credentials lose access to their account permanently.
- This must be clearly and repeatedly communicated at signup — not buried in terms of service.
- A visible warning should appear at account creation: “There is no way to recover your account. Write your username and password down somewhere safe.”

4.3 Session Handling

- Standard session/JWT-based authentication after login.
- No device fingerprinting used for identity purposes — only for abuse-rate-limiting (Section 6).
- Users can log in from multiple devices using the same username and password, since there is no device-bound identity.

5. Password Policy & Blocklist

Because there is no account recovery, password strength enforcement is more important on Whisper Pages than on a typical platform — a compromised or trivially guessed password means permanent, irreversible account loss with no safety net.

5.1 Enforcement Rules

- Minimum length of 10 characters, mixing letters, numbers, and at least one symbol.
- Real-time strength meter shown at signup (weak / medium / strong).
- Hard rejection of any password matching the blocklist, regardless of strength score.

5.2 Blocklist Source

The blocklist will be compiled from known common/breached password datasets (such as the widely used “rockyou”-style compilations and SecLists common-password lists), normalized and deduplicated into a lookup file used at signup time. This file should be updated periodically as new breach data becomes public.

5.3 Storage

- Passwords are never stored in plaintext — hashed with a modern algorithm (bcrypt or argon2) with per-user salt.
- The blocklist check happens against the plaintext value at signup time only, before hashing, and is never logged.

6. Writer Profiles

Every pen name has a public profile page functioning similarly to an Instagram-style portfolio — but scoped strictly to that pen name's body of work, never to a real person.

6.1 What a Profile Shows

- Pen name, join date (month/year only), and total post count.
- Full archive of published writing, browsable and sortable by date or popularity.
- Aggregate stats: total likes received, total comments received.
- Bio field, self-written, with no verification of any claims made in it.

6.2 What a Profile Never Shows

- No linkage to any other pen name, even internally in admin tooling for display purposes.
- No location, device, or demographic data of any kind.
- No “mutual followers” or social-graph-style suggestions.

6.3 Design Tension Acknowledged

Public profiles sit in some tension with the platform's “no identity profiling” pitch. The resolution is that a profile represents the pen name's body of work, not a person — there is no mechanism, public or internal, that connects a pen name back to a real-world identity or to other pen names the same person may hold.

7. Writing, Publishing & Discovery

7.1 Publishing

- Rich-text editor supporting paragraphs, basic formatting, and embedded chapter breaks for multi-part stories.
- Draft autosave (client-side and periodic server-side) is strongly recommended given the lack of account recovery — losing a draft to a session timeout would be unusually costly here.
- Optional “Series” grouping so multi-part stories display as a connected sequence on the writer's profile.

7.2 Reading & Browsing

Reading, browsing, and searching content requires no account whatsoever — this is the platform's primary growth funnel. A logged-out visitor can read any publicly visible story in full.

7.3 What Requires Login

Action	Login Required?
Read a published story	No
Browse / search by tag or genre	No
Like or dislike a story	Yes
Comment on a story	Yes
Report content	Yes
Visit a writer's full profile	Yes
Publish writing	Yes

7.4 Discovery

- Discovery is tag- and genre-based, not identity-based — no “follow this person” graph, consistent with the no-profiling philosophy.
- A “trending” feed ranked by recent likes/comments, refreshed periodically.
- Logged-out visitors see a public preview (opening paragraph) of trending stories for SEO and discovery, with full text gated behind login.

8. Age Certification System

Whisper Pages uses a dual self-certification model rather than formal age verification, since verified ID checks would conflict directly with the platform's anonymity guarantee. This is understood to be a trust-based system, not a hard technical guarantee — its purpose is to set safe defaults and reduce (not eliminate) the chance of age-inappropriate exposure.

8.1 Two Separate Mechanisms

Viewer Age Bracket: Set once at signup. Determines what content categories a reader's account can see.

Content Age Rating: Set by the writer at publish time for each piece (e.g., general / mature / 18+). Determines the minimum viewer bracket required to view it.

8.2 Enforcement Defaults

- Content rated 18+ is never shown to accounts self-certified under 18, with no override or opt-in bypass.
- Accounts self-certified as under 18 have comments and messages from self-certified adult accounts restricted by default.
- Writers are shown a mandatory rating prompt before a piece can be published; there is no “unrated” publish path.

8.3 Known Limitation

Self-certification can be falsified by any user willing to lie about their age. This system should be framed publicly as a safety default and content-filtering tool, not as a guarantee of a user's real age — and should be paired with strict moderation of any content or interaction patterns that suggest an adult is deliberately targeting a minor account.

9. Confession & Shoutout Wall

A separate feed, distinct from long-form writing, where users can post short, anonymous messages — confessions, shoutouts, or open statements (e.g., “I love this person,” general life confessions) without any of the profile or portfolio structure of the writing section.

9.1 Why It's Separated

The Wall is a fundamentally different content type from stories — short, impulsive, often about real third parties rather than original creative writing. Mixing it into the main writing feed would dilute both experiences, so it lives in its own section entirely.

9.2 Elevated Risk Profile

Because Wall posts frequently reference real, identifiable people who have not consented to being written about, this feature carries meaningfully higher harassment and stalking risk than the writing section, and is treated with stricter safeguards.

Wall-Specific Safeguards

- Stricter automated word/pattern filtering than the main site, tuned for harassment and identifying details.
- Posts are fire-and-forget by default (no threaded replies), to avoid Wall posts turning into public discussion threads about a real, non-consenting person.
- Lower report threshold for auto-hide compared to standard story content, given the higher potential for real-world harm.

10. Engagement: Likes, Comments, Reporting

10.1 Likes & Dislikes

- Require a logged-in account — prevents bot/anonymous vote manipulation and keeps engagement metrics meaningful.
- A pen name can like/dislike a given piece once; toggled, not stacked.

10.2 Comments

- Require a logged-in account and are tied to the commenter's pen name, so writers can identify and moderate repeat abusive commenters without knowing who they “really” are.
- Writers can delete comments on their own work and block the commenting pen name from further interaction (Section 11).

10.3 Reporting

- Any logged-in user can report a story, comment, or Wall post for violating guidelines.
- Reports feed the auto-hide system described in Section 12.
- The reporting user's identity is visible only to admin moderation tooling, never to the reported writer.

11. Blocking & Muting

Since writers can see all engagement on their own work but have no way to know who a commenting pen name “really” is, blocking operates entirely at the pen-name level.

- A writer can block a specific pen name from commenting, liking, or messaging them further.
- Blocking is one-directional and silent — the blocked pen name is not notified.
- Blocked pen names can still read the writer's public work (blocking restricts interaction, not visibility), consistent with the open-reading philosophy.

12. Content Moderation & Auto-Hide System

12.1 Layers of Moderation

6. Blocklist filtering at submission time for explicit prohibited terms, including child-abuse-related language, which is rejected outright and never published.
7. Community reporting, with content automatically hidden pending review once it crosses a report threshold (N reports, tuned separately for stories, comments, and Wall posts).
8. Manual admin review of hidden/reported content, with the power to permanently remove content or restore it if reports were unfounded.

12.2 Why Blocklists Alone Are Insufficient

Word-based blocklists catch explicit terms but miss coded language, context-dependent abuse, and evolving slang. The report-driven auto-hide layer exists specifically to catch what static filtering cannot.

12.3 Content Guidelines

A pinned, plain-language community guidelines page should explain what is and is not allowed, since the platform cannot rely on identity-based accountability (real-name reputational risk) the way conventional platforms do.

13. Account Lifecycle & 300-Day Rule

13.1 Inactivity Rule

An account with no login activity for 300 consecutive days is automatically and permanently destroyed. All associated content, comments, likes, and profile data are deleted.

13.2 User-Facing Countdown

The countdown should be visible to the writer well before destruction — for example, a banner reading “This account has been inactive for 250 days. It will be permanently deleted in 50 days unless you log in.” This avoids silently destroying accounts without warning.

13.3 Pen Name Reuse

- Once an account is destroyed, its pen name becomes available for anyone to claim.
- Old content tied to the previous holder of that pen name is fully deleted, not merely unlinked, so a new holder cannot inherit reputation, search visibility, or engagement history from the previous owner.
- This policy should be stated clearly on the main page / signup flow, since it is an unusual mechanic for users to expect.

14. Feedback Widget

A persistent, simple feedback element at the bottom of the page lets users submit product ideas or bug reports directly, without needing an external form or email.

- Two separate categories — Bug Report and Feature Idea — so submissions can be triaged independently rather than mixed into one queue.
- Submissions are lightweight (short text field, optional page context) and routed to an internal admin queue, not public-facing.

15. Admin & Master Account

A single master administrator account has elevated visibility for moderation, legal compliance, and platform operation. Given the platform's anonymity guarantee to regular users, the admin account's scope and safeguards matter more than usual.

15.1 Scope of Admin Visibility

- Can view reported/hidden content and take moderation action (hide, restore, permanently remove).
- Can view a specific account's IP address and login details when necessary — for example, responding to a credible legal request or an imminent safety threat — not for routine moderation browsing.
- This scope is disclosed plainly in the public privacy policy (Section 16), rather than left as an unstated capability.

15.2 Safeguards

- Two-factor authentication is enforced situationally — specifically when admin accesses a specific user's sensitive details — rather than on every login, to avoid friction that could confuse the admin's own usage pattern.
- A full audit log records every admin action (what was viewed, hidden, or removed, and when), so there is accountability even though the action itself is not publicly visible.
- Recommended for future phases: splitting “moderator” (can act on reports) from “super admin” (can view sensitive account details, delete accounts) as separate roles once the team grows beyond a single administrator.

16. Privacy Policy Considerations

The privacy policy needs to be specific rather than vague, since “we can see your IP” without context reads as alarming even when the underlying practice is reasonable and limited.

16.1 Recommended Disclosure Language

Draft Policy Points (for legal review)

- Whisper Pages does not collect email addresses, phone numbers, or real names at any point.
- Login IP addresses and session metadata may be logged for security and legal-compliance purposes only.
- This data is accessed only in response to a credible legal request or an imminent safety threat (e.g., threats of violence, child safety concerns) — never for routine moderation or curiosity.
- Because there is no account recovery, users are responsible for remembering their own username and password; the platform cannot restore lost credentials under any circumstance.
- Destroyed (300-day-inactive) accounts have their content permanently and irreversibly deleted.

This report is not legal advice — the final privacy policy and terms of service should be reviewed by a qualified professional before launch, particularly around data retention requirements that vary by jurisdiction.

17. Seed Content Strategy

To avoid an empty platform at launch, a small batch of seed accounts will be created before public signup opens.

17.1 Approach: One-Time Seeding

- Approximately 10 seed accounts, each publishing 3–4 pieces of genuinely well-written short content — quality over quantity, since a few strong posts are more convincing than many mediocre ones.
- Created once, before launch, as a manual batch — not an ongoing automated posting schedule.
- Internally flagged (visible to admin only) as seed content, so it can be tracked and eventually retired or archived once organic content outweighs it.

17.2 Why Not Ongoing Automated Posting

A platform that appears to have active writers posting on a fixed schedule indefinitely, when those accounts are not real people, risks being perceived as astroturfing if discovered — this is a materially different trust problem than a one-time launch seed, which is a common and broadly accepted practice.

18. Technical Architecture

18.1 Recommended Stack

Layer	Recommendation
Frontend	Next.js (React), deployed on Vercel
Backend API	Node.js / Express, deployed on Render
Database	MongoDB Atlas
Authentication	Custom username/password auth, bcrypt or argon2 hashing, JWT sessions
File/Image storage	Cloudinary or Cloudflare R2 (for any profile media)
Rate limiting	IP/device-based limiter (e.g., Redis-backed) for signup and reporting abuse

18.2 Core Data Entities

- Account — pen name, hashed password, age bracket, created date, last active date, status.
- Post — content, author account reference, content age rating, tags, timestamps, series reference (optional).
- Comment — content, author account reference, target post reference, timestamps.
- Report — target type (post/comment/wall), target ID, reporting account reference, reason, status.
- Block — blocker account reference, blocked account reference.
- WallPost — content, author account reference, timestamp, report count.
- AdminAuditLog — admin action type, target, timestamp.

18.3 Security Notes

- All passwords hashed with per-user salt; blocklist check occurs pre-hash and is never logged.
- IP logging kept separate from any publicly queryable data path — accessible only through the admin-audited flow described in Section 15.
- Standard web hardening: rate limiting on auth endpoints, input sanitization, CSRF protection on state-changing requests.

19. Risks & Mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Lost credentials = permanent account loss	Repeated, prominent warnings at signup; optional future export/backup feature for writers
Anonymity enables harassment	Report-driven auto-hide, Wall-specific stricter filtering, blocking system
Falsified age self-certification	Strict default content gating regardless of claimed age; treat as safety default, not verification
Single master admin account compromise	Situational 2FA, full audit logging, future role separation
Pen name reuse confusion	Full deletion (not just unlinking) of prior content; clear public messaging on reuse policy
Seed/bot content perceived as deceptive	One-time launch batch only, internally flagged, retired once organic content dominates

20. Phased Roadmap

Phase 1 — Core Platform (MVP)

- Username/password auth with blocklist, age self-certification, writer profiles.
- Publish/read flow, tag-based browsing, likes/comments, reporting with auto-hide.
- Blocking, feedback widget, admin panel with audit log, one-time seed content.

Phase 2 — Wall & Lifecycle

- Confession/shoutout Wall with elevated moderation.
- 300-day inactivity destruction and pen name reuse logic.
- Draft autosave.

Phase 3 — Refinement

- Situational 2FA for admin, role separation (moderator vs super admin).
- Series/multi-part story grouping, writer export/backup tool.
- Expanded discovery (trending refinements, tag recommendations).

21. Appendix: Glossary

Pen Name: The only identity a user has on Whisper Pages; equivalent to a username.

Content Age Rating: A rating assigned by the writer at publish time controlling minimum viewer age bracket.

Viewer Age Bracket: A reader's self-certified age group, used to filter visible content.

Auto-Hide: Automatic, temporary hiding of content once it crosses a report threshold, pending admin review.

Seed Content: A one-time batch of pre-written posts published by admin-created accounts at launch.

300-Day Rule: Automatic, permanent account and content deletion after 300 days of inactivity.

End of Report.